SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #54 · WORK AND CALLING

“If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me.”

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Where it often comes from

Productivity can become a moral standard. Lists, goals, and income can turn into a daily scoreboard. Every unproductive hour can seem like a failure, and illness, caregiving, unemployment, or old age can feel like waste. Many of us were praised when we achieved and ignored when we rested.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist prays, “So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom.” Paul says, “We are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life,” so God prepares the works. When Martha was busy and worried, Jesus said, “only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion.” God also says, “Be still and know that I am God.” A well-lived life is measured by wisdom, love, and presence, not output.

> *“So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom”* (Psalm 90:12).

Also see

> “For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life” (Ephesians 2:10).

> “‘Martha, Martha,’ the Lord replied, ‘you are worried and upset about many things. But only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion, and it will not be taken away from her.’” (Luke 10:41–42).

> “‘Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.’” (Psalm 46:10).

> “He has shown you, O man, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you but to act justly, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God?” (Micah 6:8).

Common self-statements

- Every unproductive minute is a waste.
- I must always accomplish something.
- Time off is a failure.
- Being sick means I am useless.
- I am only valuable when I produce.
- I will regret all the time I wasted.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must always be productive.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing time as either productive or wasted.
- Labeling: Calling myself a waster.
- Magnification: Treating rest or slow seasons as huge failures.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me to measure life by output?

- What do Scripture's verses on wisdom say about how to number my days?
- What did Jesus say about Mary's choice?
- What things in life matter that cannot be measured, such as love, prayer, or presence?
- What is God doing in seasons when I cannot produce?
- What would a good day look like that is not measured by tasks?

Truth summary

> My life is not measured by output. God prepared good works for me, and He also calls me to be still, to love, and to sit at His feet. A season of rest or slowness is not wasted in His hands.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Meditation
- Thinking, Healthy
- Wisdom
- Tired
- God, First/Only

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Weak/Tired

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns
Honest distress can coexist with faith and hope in God.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me to measure life by output?
- ☐ What matters that cannot be measured?
- ☐ What was Mary's good portion?
- ☐ What does stillness teach me?
- ☐ What would a good day look like?
- ☐ What is God doing in slow seasons?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God numbers my days with wisdom.
- ☐ He prepared good works for me.
- ☐ Sitting at His feet is the good portion.
- ☐ Stillness is part of faith.
- ☐ Love and presence matter.
- ☐ No season is wasted in His hands.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 90:12
  "So teach us to number our days, that we may present a heart of wisdom."
- ☐ Ephesians 2:10
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ Luke 10:41–42
  "'Martha, Martha,' the Lord replied, 'you are worried and upset about many things. But only one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion, and it will not be taken away from her.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] The good portion: Each day, write one unmeasured thing that mattered, such as a conversation, a prayer, or a moment outdoors.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 90:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Teach me to number my days, that I may have a heart of wisdom.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Wisdom" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Write your scoreboard. List how you measure a good day and who taught it.
- [ ] Add a non-task item. Put time with God or a loved one on your list.
- [ ] Sit still. Spend 10 minutes in quiet with Psalm 46:10.
- [ ] Review your week by love. Note moments of love and kindness, not just tasks.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	What mattered
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I'm not productive, I'm wasting the life God gave me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, teach me to number my days with wisdom. Free me from measuring my worth by output. Help me sit at Your feet, do the works You prepared, and trust that no season is wasted. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.